

Oppression and Resistance in the trilogy of *The Hunger Games*

by

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## TABLE OF CONTENTS:

|                                                                                                                       |           |
|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------|
| <b>Abstract.....</b>                                                                                                  | <b>3</b>  |
| <b>Introduction.....</b>                                                                                              | <b>4</b>  |
| <b>Chapter 1: Oppression of the Impoverished Youth Through the Hunger Games.....</b>                                  | <b>6</b>  |
| <b>Chapter 2: Oppression of the Impoverished Districts Through the Lack of Resources..</b>                            | <b>20</b> |
| <b>Chapter 3: Oppression of the Tributes Through Surveillance and Manipulation .....</b>                              | <b>28</b> |
| <b>Chapter 4: Oppression of the Districts’ Citizens Through Intimidation, Brutality, and<br/>Murder.....</b>          | <b>34</b> |
| <b>Chapter 5: Oppression of the “Rebels” Through Limitations, Threats, and<br/>Mutilation.....</b>                    | <b>37</b> |
| <b>Chapter 6: Oppression of the Hunger Games’ “Victors” Through Torture, Sexual Abuse,<br/>and Surveillance .....</b> | <b>41</b> |
| <b>Chapter 7: The Power of Hope in Resistance during the Revolution .....</b>                                         | <b>47</b> |
| <b>Conclusion.....</b>                                                                                                | <b>52</b> |

## Abstract

In this study, I examine oppression and resistance in Suzanne Collins' trilogy *The Hunger Games* (2008), *Catching Fire* (2009), and *Mockingjay* (2010). The different forms of psychological and physical abuse throughout the trilogy are alarming and result in the characters' feelings of entrapment and powerlessness. Unable to have a vote in their own lives, Collins' characters have relinquished all decision-making and their only form of resistance is directed towards survival. After many years of accepting the government's abuse, the main characters, Katniss Everdeen and Peeta Mellark, serve as catalysts for change. For the first time in many years, Katniss and Peeta provide their nation with a sense of hope, which results in the citizens' urge to reclaim their freedom. Thus, Collins suggests that the power of hope is what ultimately supplies the districts with the strength that they need to unite and to resist their abusive government. I use Marilyn Frye's article, "Oppression" as well as *Hope Under Oppression* by Katie Stockdale, among other sources, to analyze the several forms of oppression and the power of hope in the multiple layers of resistance throughout the trilogy.

## Introduction

We live in a world where social injustice and resistance are enduring issues that can be easily detected and discerned, thus the unfolding of a horrific future dominated by oppression is a common subject matter in literature. A writer who exploits this theme in a remarkable way is Suzanne Collins in her acclaimed trilogy *The Hunger Games* (2008), *Catching Fire* (2009), and *Mockingjay* (2010), in which she depicts a dystopian futuristic nation called Panem, consisting of 12 districts, a vanished 13<sup>th</sup> district, and the Capitol. Collin's interpretation of oppression in the trilogy exemplifies what American philosopher, Marilyn Frye, states in her article, "Oppression," that "The experience of oppressed people is that the living of one's life is confined and shaped by forces and barriers which are not accidental or occasional" (12). The usage of the words "confined" and "barriers" help create the image of entrapment, which is exactly how Collins portrays the citizens of Panem. The trilogy is narrated by one of the main characters and victims of oppression, Katniss Everdeen, a sixteen-year-old from District 12. It follows the storyline of a dictatorial society led by a ruthless and tyrannical leader known as President Coriolanus Snow. President Snow, along with all the other wealthy people of the nation, live in the Capitol, considered to be the ruling government of Panem. For his own amusement and satisfaction, President Snow holds an annual reaping, a lottery where the Hunger Games participants are chosen, of the poor districts' children between the ages of 12 and 18, vindicating his oppressive control over Panem. The 24 involuntary contestants, ironically called tributes, one male and one female from each district, are then expected to participate in a fight till death, which everyone in the nation watches as entertainment. This blood bath is held to remind the districts of the president's totalitarian power and to promote hatred and enmity between the districts. This form of public punishment in the trilogy originates from a time when

the ancestors of the districts tried to rebel against the Capitol. Unfortunately, the Hunger Games are not the only form of oppression in Panem; in fact, oppression takes many forms throughout the trilogy. Suzanne Collins depicts oppression through the cruel treatment of youth, deprivation of resources in the poor districts, abuse of the tributes throughout the games, abuse of the districts' citizens by Peacekeepers, punishment of those who rebel, and the unfair treatment of the Hunger Games' Victors. The main characters, whom the trilogy revolves around, Katniss Everdeen and Peeta Mellark, are chosen to represent District 12 in the 74<sup>th</sup> Hunger Games. They enter the arena as rivals, but to ensure their survival, astutely become an alliance. Although there is usually only one winner in the Hunger Games, surprisingly, the rules get changed and both Katniss and Peeta are announced Victors. Nonetheless, their actions in the games cause commotion and confusion among the districts, which President Snow does not take lightly. President Snow considers Katniss and Peeta a threat, and thus changes the rules of the Hunger Games once again. In the 75<sup>th</sup> games, the tributes are to be reaped from the existing pool of Victors- which leads to Katniss and Peeta entering the arena again. The tributes from every district are infuriated for they have been promised immunity from future Hunger Games. Consequently, there is much rebellion in *Catching Fire*, which ultimately leads to the rebels helping to break out some of the tributes from the arena. However, the real war begins in *Mockingjay*, which finally leads to the overthrowing of the dictatorship. Although oppression can damage the ability to hope, it is hope, promoted by Katniss Everdeen, and the unity of the districts that leads to this political overthrow. In a fascinating way, Suzanne Collins intertwines different forms of oppression with multiple layers of resistance throughout the trilogy to reveal the power of hope and the importance of coming together in the face of social injustice.

## Chapter 1: Oppression of the Impoverished Youth through the Hunger Games

As aforementioned, a clear form of oppression that is evident throughout the entire trilogy is that of the poor districts' youth, which is manifested through their forced participation in the annual Hunger Games where they must kill each other to stay alive. The government uses the Hunger Games to maintain the 12 districts segregated and to ensure their enmity so that there are no rebellions. Starting at the age of 12, until the age of 18, each year, their names are added into the reaping, once more than the previous year, resulting in a higher chance to "win" entry into the Hunger-Games arena as they get older. This form of oppression is not just physical; it is also psychological. Children live in fear, awaiting a fate over which they have no control. Not only are they afraid for their lives, but they are also afraid of ever becoming parents. In *The Hunger Games*, Katniss despondently declares, "I never want to have kids" (Hunger 9). Given Collin's portrayal of Katniss as headstrong and rebellious, I assume that in her case it is not fear that impels her to make such a statement, but her willfulness and passive-resistant attitude. Certainly, she is aware of the kind of life her children would have to endure; imagining her own children living her life, killing to survive, or dying in the hands of another child is inconceivable to her. However, she is also aware that there would not be any games if there were no children, which makes me wonder why the people of Panem continue to have children, thus adding stress to their lives. The fact that Katniss has the freedom to decide whether to have children or not tells me that the other citizens of Panem could easily do the same. Regardless, it can be inferred that compulsory heteroreproductivity is an ascribed expectation for the citizens of Panem for it is implied by the fact that Katniss is forced into a relationship with Peeta to survive the Hunger Games. It can also be inferred that children provide their families with a glimpse of hope and happiness; it is what keeps them alive and moving forward. Nonetheless, children throughout the

trilogy are represented as both positive and negative since they are also perceived as part of the destruction of hope, as seeing their children die is extremely traumatic to the districts. Katniss mentions, “Whatever words they use, the real message is clear. ‘Look how we take your children and sacrifice them and there’s nothing you can do. If you lift a finger, we will destroy every last one of you” (Hunger 19). Katniss uses the word “they” referring to the Capitol, specifically President Snow. She then proceeds to mimic the Capitol by divulging their undisclosed message, which is that the people of Panem are entrapped just like Frye mentions in her article. Katniss’s best friend and hunting partner, Gale, responds to Katniss not wanting kids by saying, “I might. If I didn’t live here” (Hunger 9). Collins portrays Gale as hesitant to agree with Katniss’s statement. The words “if I didn’t live here,” as opposed to wishing that Panem were not controlled by a cruel dictator, make me think, to some extent, that Gale has given up on hope. In his mind, removing himself from District 12, which is something unfeasible considering his circumstances, seems more logical to him than fighting for change. Unlike Katniss, who at this point does not seem hopeful that her world would one day change unless she does something about it, Gale speaks about the world as if there is nothing he can do. To make things even worse for the impoverished youth, the government offers those from the districts an opportunity for tesserae, which is equal to a year’s supply of grain and oil for one person, if a child chooses to add their name yet another time into the reaping, thus raising their chances of being selected. The Capitol exploits the districts’ youth by offering this “helpful” solution to hunger while ironically raising their chances of being selected for the Hunger Games. The poorer they are, the more chances they will have to enter the games. Hence, the Capitol manipulates the poor into putting the lives of their children on the line, while also presenting the children with a moral conundrum. Afterall, how could the children, who are symbols of hope for their families, not do all they can

to ensure their families' survival? In general, impoverished children are part of the oppressive system in the trilogy since they are compelled to tesserae in exchange for their family's survival. This is clearly oppression as it is unjust and shows the Capitol's abuse of power and the helplessness of the districts' impoverished youth.

Not only are the youth expected to participate in the reaping, but they are also expected to try their best to murder each other once they enter the Hunger Games arena. In *The Hunger Games*, when Katniss's 12-year-old sister gets chosen in the reaping, Katniss immediately volunteers to take her place. This selfless act does not only show Katniss's protective, courageous, and compassionate qualities, but it also shows her willfulness and ability to resist and take control. Although she is not convinced herself, she promises her sister that she will win. This is the first ray of hope for her sister and her district. Shortly after volunteering for her sister, Katniss states, "We examine the faces of the kids who will be our competition" (Hunger 45). Katniss and Peeta must enter the arena ready to, essentially, kill other children, some of whom even younger than themselves. In fact, associate professor of political science, David R. Dryer contributes discussion to this in his article, "War, Peace, and Justice in Panem: International Relations and the Hunger Games trilogy," in which he argues that there is a zero-sum nature of competition in the games because a gain for one tribute is merely a loss for another. Dryer gives an example from the text, noting that when Katniss realizes Peeta was fighting hard to stay alive in the games, it meant he was thus fighting hard to end her life, as that is the only way to achieve his goal. For Katniss, this type of mindset is challenging, as she is not a murderer and does not take death lightly. Before leaving with the other tributes to the Capitol, Gale tells Katniss, "You've had more practice. Real practice. You know how to kill" (Hunger 41) implying that murdering other human beings to stay alive is the same as killing animals for food. This shows



Gale's desensitization to violence and the type of emotionless mindset that these children must have heading into the game to have a chance at survival. Indeed, David R. Dryer also furthers this point in his article in which he writes, "The Games are an extreme depiction of a kill-or-be-killed realist world in which only the fittest survive" (253). Here, he highlights that only the "fittest" can survive the Hunger Games, meaning the stronger ones who have had more resources such as some training. This is very interesting as it shows the violence of the games as well as social injustice. It is obvious that the chances of a severely poor district winning are significantly low due to their lack of food, resources, and training overall. Through Katniss, Suzanne Collins reminds the reader that, "It's technically against the rules to train tributes before they reach the Capitol" (Hunger 94). However, the less poor districts, such as district one, two, and four, still manage to train beforehand, as the Capitol turns a blind eye on them. These districts have certain privileges that the poorer districts do not. This highlights the fact that the districts' economic inequality plays a pivotal role in the treatment received from the government. Consequently, the poorer districts' tributes are the ones who usually die first. It is assumed by the narrator that the President favors these specific districts because they are more supportive of his tactics and the games. Katniss mentions that these tributes are referred to as "Career Tributes" and usually end up winning the games due to their strength and training. In the Career districts the Hunger Games are considered an honor; therefore, many of the children volunteer to be sent into the arena. In fact, they even fight over who gets to take part in the games because they are confident that they will win. Sadly, these children have been brainwashed to think that participating in the Hunger Games and slaughtering 23 innocent lives is the way to go, as their government has convinced them that winning the games is the only way to advance in their society and to live in comfort. It is also the only way to avoid being part of the poorer districts. All in all, the

government's oppressive tactics are evident through the mental manipulation of these tributes. Although the poorer tributes have not had the advantages and training of the Career Tributes, they are expected to be just as murderous and as skillful; they are expected to put on a show for the Capitol. One line in particular that sticks out to me is, "Only I keep wishing I could think of a way to ... to show the Capitol they don't own me. That I'm more than just a piece in their Games" (Hunger 142). The words "own" and "piece" emphasize the constraints of freedom faced by the impoverished youth and their families, as they can never make their own decisions. To the Capitol they are simply pawns in a game, rather than actual people with thoughts and feelings. By adding these impactful words into Peeta's dialogue with Katniss, Collins depicts an individual who feels helpless, like "a piece in their Games," but who wants to somehow make a difference. Without realizing it, Peeta fuels Katniss's rebellious attitude and eagerness to fight back. Katniss and Peeta know that they will be punished if they do not kill their peers and each other; they know that they must give the Capitol proper entertainment. Yet, they choose to protect one another throughout the games, providing each other and their community with hope. Hope plays a crucial role in Katniss's and Peeta's rebellion, as it would in any world consisting of social injustice. As stated in the Oxford Learner's Dictionaries, it is "hope (of something) hope (for somebody) a person, a thing, or a situation that will help you get what you want." This hope in "a person, a thing, or a situation" is shown in the trilogy as a spark for facing the oppressive system of Panem, as even the smallest bit of hope can instigate resistance. Collins immediately presents an amicable relationship between Katniss and Peeta when the two of them are reaped for the games, as they know each other from their childhood. In fact, Peeta had showed extreme kindness on one occasion when he provided bread to Katniss during a time of starvation and desperation. Thus, when Peeta becomes allies with the Career Tributes during the

74<sup>th</sup> Hunger Games, he is only doing it to stay alive so that he can protect Katniss from them. Instead of helping them find her, which is what they want Peeta for, he does the opposite. For instance, when they find her helpless, climbed up in a tree, Peeta insists that they stop attacking her and wait her out instead. He nonchalantly states, “Oh, let her stay up there. It’s not like she’s going anywhere. We’ll deal with her in the morning” (Hunger 183). By stating this, Collins is letting the reader know that Peeta wants to save Katniss, regardless of the consequences. For that reason, Peeta Mellark symbolizes hope for Katniss; he does not only save Katniss and her family from starvation, but now he is also willing to sacrifice his own life for hers. This relates to what Barbara Klonowska, assistant professor in the Institute of English at The John Paul II Catholic University, writes in her essay “On desire, failure and fear: Utopia and dystopia in contemporary cinema,” that “The last stronghold of humanity in the otherwise dehumanized world is also provided by such values as love, family and friendship, similarly discarded or explicitly prohibited in dystopian worlds and yet motivating individuals to resist the regimes that forbid them” (21). Here, Klonowska brings direct attention to resistance and what she believes is the cause of it. The systems of oppression within dystopian fiction tend to get in the way of love, family, and friendship, by creating worlds where conformity and allegiance are forced. Out of fear of their governments, people try not to get too attached to others, including their own family members. An example of this is Katniss’s mother who shows little sorrow for her daughters when they are reaped, as though she was waiting for the day it would occur. Collin’s narrator mentions, “All I can see is the woman who sat by, blank and unreachable, while her children turned to skin and bones” (Hunger 8). Katniss describes her mother as “blank” and “unreachable” implying that she was cold and uninterested in the wellbeing of her children. Although not explicitly stated, Katniss’s mother’s hopelessness is evident through her distant

behavior. Her mental state is not allowing her to even contemplate the idea of hope. The discrepancy between Katniss's mother's pessimistic attitude and Katniss's optimistic attitude emphasizes human differences in relation to how individuals perceive and experience hope. Although Katniss and her mother belong to the same social group, it is evident that there are other factors, such as their age and life experiences, that play an important role in their perception of hope. Katniss's mother has lived a long life of oppression causing her mental distress and lack of hope, while Katniss is only 16 years old and has a higher propensity to take risks. Nevertheless, I think Collins would agree with Klonowska's perspective that love, family, and friendship are the essential ingredients for hope because this is supported by her portrayal of Katniss and Peeta throughout the trilogy; it is their love for each other, their love for their family, and their compassion towards others that ignites their resistance against their corrupt government. This is further backed up when the Gamemakers inadvertently change the original rules of the Hunger Games from one Victor to two Victors, if they are from the same district, only to ultimately restore the original rule at the end of the game when only Katniss and Peeta remain. Enraged by the Gamemaker's last-minute decision, and triggered by hope, Katniss and Peeta refuse to kill each other and instead fake a dyadic suicide. Katniss cleverly decides to pretend as though the two of them are going to commit suicide with poisonous berries because she is aware that the government needs a winner. Therefore, she is using the government's own rules against them to ensure her and Peeta's survival. By doing this, Peeta and Katniss showcase their strong bond while opposing the government; they let the government know that they are fighting together and that they are not afraid. Although Collins has Katniss brilliantly play off this rebellious act by pretending it is an act of true love, it is obvious to President Snow and the districts that this is a form of resistance. In fact, in *Catching Fire*, President Snow appears at

Katniss's home to tell her, "I have a problem, Miss Everdeen. A problem that began the moment you pulled out those poisonous berries in the arena" (Catching 20). President Snow recognizes the threat that Katniss poses to his reign. By allowing Katniss's defiant behavior, he is opening the doors to further insubordination on behalf of the districts. He goes on to confirm his suspicions by stating, "If a girl from District Twelve of all places can defy the Capitol and walk away unharmed, what is to stop them from doing the same? What is to prevent, say, an uprising?" (Catching 21). Here, President Snow first brings attention to Katniss' district, as District 12 is not one of the wealthier districts, but rather one of the poorest. The fact he points out her poverty means that he does not believe anyone poor should dare resist; he would expect that from a richer district, such as the Career ones. He then points out that Katniss has been allowed to leave the arena "unharmed" which suggests President Snow had nothing to do with the Head Gamemaker's decision which allowed her to live. Furthermore, he himself shows concern over the possibility of an "uprising" that Katniss may have inspired in others. A possible uprising is not something to take lightly as until then the districts had been fearful of proposing any objection to the Capitol. Therefore, President Snow is intimidated by the symbol of hope that Katniss has become for the districts, as he knows hope is a strong feeling that can lead to resistance. It becomes clear that his fears are justified as later in *Catching Fire*, when the returning Victors are interviewed for the 75<sup>th</sup> Hunger Games, multiple of them speak their minds and hold hands to show solidarity. In this moment, Collins brings attention to the importance of hope and unity in the face of oppression. As mentioned previously, friendship plays a big role in the emergence of hope which eventually leads to resistance in the novel. During the 75<sup>th</sup> Hunger Games, there is a sense of brotherhood and solidarity within the Victors as they all understand what each other has gone through; they have all been deceived into thinking that they would live

a life of comfort, safe from future games. The anger of the Victors, from being taken advantage of, turns out to be an effective weapon against the oppressive government. Consequently, Collins' characters start to evolve, showing that they are not afraid to show resistance against the Capitol. Whereas only small individual acts of resistance had happened up until this incident, the 75<sup>th</sup> Hunger Games are fueled with collective emotions, which lead to collective resistance. The government is justifiably frightened that the districts will start to rebel, partially due to Katniss's rebellious act with the berries, so they want to show the districts that they are in control and hold power over the Victors' lives. Nevertheless, the Victors do not remain quiet; instead, they vocalize their distress. For instance, Beetee, the male tribute from District 3 and Victor of the 39<sup>th</sup> Hunger Games, questions the legality of the new rules in the 75<sup>th</sup> Hunger Games, thus going against the government. By doing so, he is essentially questioning the Capitol themselves, which consequently places a target on his back. Additionally, Finnick, the male tribute from District 4 and Victor of the 65<sup>th</sup> Hunger Games, recites a poem about his one true love, a girl from his district, resulting in empathy within the Capitol's people and taking away any positive attention from the games. Johanna, the female tribute from District 7 and Victor of the 71<sup>st</sup> Hunger Games, asks if anything can be done to stop the games altogether. Furthermore, the novel's female protagonist, Katniss, wears a dress that transforms into wings, making her a Mockingjay, a species of bird in the novel that resulted from a failed Capitol project, reminding the audience of the Capitol's failure. Yet again, Katniss is confirmed as a symbol of hope for the districts; she becomes living proof that resistance is not impossible. As mentioned in *Hope Under Oppression* by assistant professor of philosophy at the University of Victoria, Katie Stockdale, "hope, then, can be understood as a way of seeing or perceiving in a favorable light the possibility that a desired outcome will be realized" (Stockdale 18). Therefore, Stockdale suggests that people hope

when they think that there is a chance that their goal could be accomplished. To the districts, Katniss is proof of this very hope of possible change as she survives after rebelling against the government. Someone in the novel specifically moved by the power of hope that Katniss brings forth is Cinna, the stylist and designer of Katniss's Mockingjay gown. Katniss states, "Suddenly I am so afraid for him. What has he done? Something terribly dangerous. An act of rebellion in itself" (Catching 253). Collins uses the words "dangerous" and "rebellion" to highlight the severity of what Cinna has done by creating an attire so symbolic of the rebellion. Cinna has deliberately committed an act of resistance and will most likely have to face negative consequences as the government will not take this lightly. By wearing the Mockingjay dress, Katniss is letting the districts know that this is the beginning of a revolution. In "Discipline and the Docile Body: Regulating Hungers in the Capitol," Christina Van Dyke, professor of philosophy at Columbia University, mentions that Cinna's "brilliant efforts" make clear that "body modifications" are "an effective means of resistance to dominant power structures" (15). I agree with Van Dyke's perspective because Cinna's body modification of Katniss proves to be an effective tool of protest. He does not need to resist verbally or physically, as his work makes an incredible impact toward resistance. I should clarify that the usage of the phrase "body modifications" does not only refer to the Mockingjay gown, but also to the dramatic appearances described of the individuals who reside in the Capitol. The people of the Capitol dress in vibrant colors and exotic gowns, showing their wealth and own self-expression with their outfits. Additionally, Peeta also rebels by lying and saying that Katniss is pregnant. By doing this, he is labeling the government as cruel dictators who would have a pregnant woman and her baby sent to their death. Even though the Capitol's people had not demonstrated any emotions or concern for Katniss or for any of the other tributes in the arena, they are suddenly alarmed at the thought

of a pregnant woman entering the games. Did they suddenly forget that Katniss is also a child? Did they forget all the previous Hunger Games that contained only children? This makes me question the morality of the citizens of the Capitol, who do not bat an eye at the oppression in the world around them. By blindly partaking in their cruel dictatorship, they are a part of the political problem. Van Dyke goes on to mention in her article, “The more time and energy the Capitol citizens focus on body-modification and their social lives, the more self-focused they become... and the less likely they are to notice or care about political injustices that don’t directly affect them” (2). This quote further emphasizes the egoistic traits of the citizens of the Capitol, who do not care about anything that does not “directly affect them.” The citizens of the Capitol are too busy with trivial matters; since they do not have to deal with oppression, they do not care about those in the districts who do. Overall, unlike the citizens of the Capitol, the participants of the 75<sup>th</sup> Hunger Games clearly have hope that together, with the support of one another, they can propel the cancelation of the games, thus contemplating a possible end to their oppression.

Collins also renders oppression through the lack of empathy of the young tributes in the annual Hunger Games. These young tributes do not mourn each other’s deaths; instead, they kill and move on to their next target as the Capitol wants to see tributes fighting until death, showing no mercy. If a tribute shows mercy for another tribute, it is considered an act of betrayal or rebellion as it would show district unity. District unity frightens the Capitol as with enough consensus and unity the districts could overpower them and reclaim control. The Capitol will do anything in their power to ensure they retain all the power. Collins suggests that, at the end of the day, governments have no morals when it comes to accomplishing their goals, as the government in this trilogy is motivated primarily by power and control. Yet, Collins’s fictional government is met with resistance by Katniss and Peeta, thus ruining their goals of having complete power in



the outcome of the games. In the 74<sup>th</sup> Hunger Games, the youngest tribute is a twelve-year-old girl from District 11, who Katniss describes as reminding her of her younger sister Primrose. Although they are from different districts and opponents, Rue and Katniss become allies in the game and help each other stay alive, so when Rue gets murdered in front of Katniss, she is, of course, heartbroken. As a form of resistance, Katniss thinks to herself, “I want to do something, right here, right now, to shame them, to make them accountable, to show the Capitol that whatever they do or force us to do there is a part of every tribute they can’t own. That Rue was more than a piece in their Games. And so am I” (Hunger 237). Here, she shows compassion for another tribute by highlighting the loss that is Rue’s life, which is essentially going against the Capitol’s wishes. Katniss goes against what the games stand for, which is to display the Capitol’s power and to remind the districts of their powerlessness. Courageously, Katniss defies the Capitol’s power by giving Rue a proper burial, which she does by decorating her dead body with flowers before the Gamemakers take it away. By doing this, Katniss shows resistance through empathy and lets President Snow know that he is not in full control like he thinks. Inadvertently, her actions begin to stir up hope within the districts. Thus, not only does hope promote resistance, but resistance promotes hope within the trilogy. The death of young Rue hurts the districts very deeply, especially Rue’s District 11, as she was innocent and taken too soon. In fact, shortly after Rue’s death, Katniss receives a sponsored gift: a loaf of bread from District 11. She points out, “This is a first. A district gift to a tribute who’s not your own” (Hunger 239). It is not expected for a district to favor a tribute from another district. Therefore, this “district gift” is merely another sign of hope and resistance to oppression. The districts are hopeful for change, as Katniss herself has created change by displaying empathy for another tribute. Moreover, throughout the 74<sup>th</sup> and 75<sup>th</sup> Hunger Games, Katniss defies certain expectations placed upon the

districts, thus encouraging others to want to do the same. Plutarch Heavensbee, the Head Gamemaker of the 75<sup>th</sup> Hunger Games, even tells her, “You’re the Mockingjay, Katniss. While you live, the revolution lives” (Catching 386). Plutarch directly points out that Katniss is the fuel the districts needed to fight back. Katniss’s simple act of empathy provides tremendous hope to the districts, henceforth encouraging resistance against the Capitol.

The Capitol is aware that seeing a child die is a traumatic experience, not just for the parent, but for everyone watching, which further shows the intended psychological effect that oppression has on the districts. President Snow finds the worst psychological torture and exploits it against these impoverished individuals. He purposely chooses children for the Hunger Games because children are symbols of hope for their parents; thus, this loss destroys any hope they may have. This form of psychological torture ensures fear of recurrence in the districts since it reminds rebels of what they have caused, thus putting the blame on them for their own children’s deaths. Why punish children for something that they did not do and most likely do not even understand? Katniss mentions early on in *The Hunger Games*, “Family members line up around the perimeter, holding tightly to one another’s hands. But there are others, too, who have no one they love at stake, or who no longer care, who slip among the crowd, taking bets on the two kids whose names will be drawn” (Hunger 17). The phrase “holding tightly to one another’s hands,” shows collective pain while the phrase “others who no longer care,” shows that they have also accepted their situation. This further reinforces what Klonowska writes in her article, “On desire, failure and fear: Utopia and dystopia in contemporary cinema” that, “Love, as an act of free choice, disinterested and impractical, is probably the single most powerful motivation standing behind rebellions in dystopian worlds and leading to their questioning or even overthrowing. It is the best embodiment of the spirit of resistance and rebellion” (21). She highlights the importance

of love in encouraging someone to advocate and support a rebellion, as people will fight wholeheartedly for those they love. The strength of love is shown in the trilogy, specifically when Katniss volunteers for her sister Primrose in the 74<sup>th</sup> Hunger Games. Katniss' love overpowers her to the point where she would sacrifice her own life without hesitation. Overall, President Snow's attempts at instilling fear are nothing compared to the power of hope that Katniss unknowingly provides to the districts who ultimately come together to battle against the Capitol.

## Chapter 2: Oppression of the Impoverished Districts through the Lack of Resources

Throughout the trilogy, Suzanne Collins depicts oppression, not just by having the districts' youth participate in such horrific games, but also by creating a government that impoverishes the districts through the deprivation of food, weaponry gear, and medical care, among other resources. Katniss points out, "Starvation's not an uncommon fate in District 12. Who hasn't seen the victims? Older people who can't work. Children from a family with too many to feed" (Hunger 28). This highlights the poor state of District 12 regarding food and lack of employment. The resources are so scarce that Katniss and Gale illegally hunt for food. Collins has Katniss point out, "Even though trespassing in the woods is illegal and poaching carries the severest of penalties, more people would risk it if they had weapons" (Hunger 5). Although she points out that hunting is "illegal" and "carries the severest of penalties," Katniss and Gale disregard these rules so that they can feed their families. It is obvious that Katniss gets her rebellious attitude from her deceased father, for it is he who taught her how to hunt. Katniss first meets Gale while he is setting snares in the forest searching for food, which shows me Gale was most likely also taught to hunt by his father. This is interesting to me as both Katniss' father and Gale's father would have been considered rebels by the government, and it just so happens that both die in the same mining accident. Although not stated, it can be inferred that this could have been purposely caused by President Snow to rid himself of two rebels and to preserve his control over the districts. As we find out in *Catching Fire*, President Snow is aware of Katniss' hunting activities when he threatens, "You aren't doing him a favor by disappearing into the woods with him each Sunday" (Catching 24). The "him" he is referring to here is Gale. This shows the reader that Snow keeps tabs on the forests, and that he might have known about Katniss's and Gale's fathers' secret hunting. If Collins is implying that Katniss's and Gale's fathers were

murdered, this would mean that the government has been silently removing their threats for years. Moreover, Collins is implying that just like oppression, resistance is also passed on through generations. When her father dies, Katniss becomes the provider. She mentions, “At eleven years old, with Prim just seven, I took over as head of the family” (Hunger 27). Although young, Katniss uses everything she learned from her father to make ends meet. If it were not for Katniss, her family would starve. She provides food for her family and sells the rest in the district’s black market, which suggests that a spirit of rebellion has always existed though it may have only been directed towards survival. The black market in District 12 is a hotspot for trade and sales. Even some of the Peacekeepers, who are the district’s main law enforcement, buy from Katniss. This form of resistance on behalf of Katniss shows bravery, as well as self-reliance, since she is fully aware that hunting could result in severe punishment, but she still does it. Moreover, her resistance emphasizes oppression as well as human resilience since Katniss breaks the rules to ensure her family’s survival in a tyrannical society.

The lack of food is not the only deprivation within the districts; there is also a lack of healthcare. On one occasion, when Gale is injured badly, Katniss’s immediate thought is to take him to her mother who practices medicine as an apothecary. It is implied that she is the only person who would be able to save him in her district. This shows the lack of medical care in District 12, as the only apparent option to save Gale’s life is Katniss’ mother’s homemade remedies. On another occasion, Katniss points out, “I scoop up a handful of snow and press it against my cheek, numbing a bit of the pain” (Catching 110). This slight detail of using a “handful of snow” as a form of anesthetic instead of an ice pack or pain killers makes deprivation evident in Panem. Although they exist in a futuristic world, the districts’ resources and methods are old-fashioned due to the unfair treatment of the districts. The lack of healthcare

in the districts is also evident through the knowledge of the tributes regarding natural remedies. Due to the lack of medical supplies and equipment, the tributes need to manage their health on their own. For instance, when Peeta's leg is injured, Katniss is immediately aware of what she should do. Katniss describes, "I have to dig the stingers out of his tracker jacker lumps, which causes him to wince, but the minute I apply the leaves he sighs in relief" (Hunger 255). She immediately knows how to remove the irritant and which healing leaves to place on him. Even though Katniss does not intensely share her mother's apothecary knowledge, she knows these skills because they are a necessity in the world that she lives in. This shows the abuse from the Capitol who controls even the health of the impoverished; the government decides who lives and who dies. Furthermore, as the games continue, we find out it is not only Katniss with this medicinal knowledge; Rue, who is much younger than Katniss, also knows how to treat injuries. When Katniss is stung by tracker jackers, another one of the Capitol's mutations that cause swelling, hallucinations, and possibly death, Rue heals Katniss's severe injuries. Katniss points out, "Rue places the handful of leaves into her mouth and begins to chew them. My mother would use other methods, but it's not like we have a lot of options. After a minute or so, Rue presses a gloppy green wad of chewed leaves and spit on my knee" (Hunger 200). It is evident that Rue has extensive knowledge of homemade remedies for healthcare as she "places the handful of leaves into her mouth" without second guessing their effects. This also confirms that districts do not communicate with one another and that they are resourceful when it comes to survival since they all have their own healthcare methods. Through the lack of healthcare, the Capitol is disturbing the districts' mental and physical wellness given that not having a hospital for emergencies can result in death and in a lot of mental stress. In a way, the districts'

resourcefulness shows resistance because they are working together, as a community, to help each other and to cope with the lack of healthcare.

To emphasize social inequality through resources, Suzanne Collins is very descriptive when it comes to the Capitol's flourishing wealth. For instance, in *Catching Fire*, after their victory in the 74<sup>th</sup> Hunger Games, Katniss and Peeta attend an event in the Capitol where they see the wealthy members of the Capitol admit to drinking a concoction at parties to make themselves throw up so that they can continue eating more. Katniss's prep team from the Capitol tells her, "Of course, so you can keep eating. I've been in there twice already. Everybody does it, or else how would you have any fun at a feast?" (Catching 79). They have overabundant amounts of food, so much that they are wasteful with it. The government keeps the Capitol's citizens satisfied and loyal by providing this overabundance of food, every meal they could ever imagine. Those of the Capitol have no reason to risk their status to support the districts' people, as they are too busy enjoying their own lives. In "Discipline and the Docile Body: Regulating Hungers in the Capitol" Van Dyke proposes that, "The citizens never experience the gnawing sensation of an empty belly; their every appetite is satisfied as soon as it arises. In stark contrast to the poorer districts (especially areas like the Seam in District 12), rich food appears ready-made at the touch of a button, and the hardest choice families face at meal times is which dishes to eat" (2). Van Dyke makes an important point of considering how the Capitol citizens lack sympathy for the districts supporting the Capitol wholeheartedly, as they cannot relate to this maltreatment. Additionally, Van Dyke points out the abundance of food they have, and how it makes choosing a meal difficult, which contributes to why they felt that they had to drink the concoction to throw up and consume all the food options. This overindulgence of food that Collins depicts in the trilogy could be an allusion to historical Roman feasts which, in a similar

manner, were hours long, lavished, and with many different food options. They were not just meals; they were spectacles to show wealth and power since having an overabundance of food was a symbol of high status. In other words, while the poor are barely eating enough to stay alive, the wealthy are overeating for fun. Peeta and Katniss are disgusted by the wastefulness of the Capitol, as they come from a home much different from those of the Capitol. Katniss points out, “All I can think of is the emaciated bodies of the children on our kitchen table as my mother prescribes what the parents can’t give. More food” (Catching 80). By having Katniss describe the bodies as “emaciated,” Collins helps the reader visualize the contrast between the wealth in the Capitol and the level of starvation in the districts. Additionally, by having Katniss use the word “prescribes,” Collins implies that food is the medicine and the hope they need; food is their salvation, but there is none.

All the districts lack resources, even the richer ones, such as Districts 1, 2 and 4, as a form of control by the government. The reader learns that although each district has their own “resource” that they produce, they are still not granted any of it for their hard work. When Rue and Katniss discuss their districts with each other, Rue mentions that even though her district grows food they are not allowed to eat the crops; they would get whipped in front of everybody if they tried. The fact that they grow the crops, smell them, and see them grow, but cannot enjoy them, is a cruel way for President Snow to oppress the citizens of Panem. On one occasion, Plutarch tells Katniss about a Latin Capitol-saying called “Panem et Circenses,” which translates to “Bread and Circuses.” He mentions that in return for full bellies and entertainment, “people had given up their political responsibilities and therefore their power” (Mockingjay 223). The “Bread” refers to the districts who provide the very food that the Capitol enjoys and they themselves lack, and the “Circuses” refers to the Capitol’s forms of entertainment which would



include their overeating, their colorful and extravagant attires, their televised Hunger Games, and so on. This further shows the grasp that the Capitol has on their citizens as they are the only ones able to provide “full bellies and entertainment” and consequently hold all the power. However, “Panem et Circenses” also suggests to me the immense power that the districts unknowingly have; if they stopped harvesting these resources, the Capitol would starve. This confirms that the government uses food as a weapon to retain control of the districts and the Capitol. President Snow gets to decide who eats, what they eat, and when they eat. In the article, “Reflections of the Surveillance and Oppressive Authority in *The Hunger Games Trilogy*” Mesut Günenç writes, “Because there is no authorization to trade across districts, they must wait for a decision from Capitol to cope with their hunger. The Capitol is the only source of current sustenance for citizens since they are unable to interact with other regions of the country, or they continue to hunt out of dread of the Capitol” (1091). Basically, the people in a district cannot interact with anyone out of their district, thus they are only able to consume the food given to them by the Capitol, which is a very limited amount. If the Capitol decides not to give them enough food one month, they will simply have nothing. As the article mentions, they could of course, hunt, but that would be breaking a law, which could lead to severe punishment. This is not just cruel because it is tantalizing to the starving people of the districts, but also because the districts are aware of the Capitol’s wastefulness. The impoverished people of Panem are forced to live a life of starvation. There is no way out. As Marilyn Frye explains in her essay “Oppression,” oppression is “the experience of being caged in: All avenues, in every direction, are blocked or booby trapped” (12). This is a perfect representation of how the characters in Collins’ trilogy feel. They are “caged in” as they are imprisoned in their own districts and to lives of starvation and suffering. Frye explains that not only are oppressed individuals confined but also “booby

trapped” which suggests that the escape is challenging, almost impossible. This is evident in the trilogy as the government always reminds their citizens of the repercussions of resistance, thus discouraging them from even attempting an escape. Therefore, the districts mournfully must accept that the Capitol holds their lives in their hands. The districts’ food deprivation is also shown through their amazement at simple basic foods such as bread. For instance, when Gale is able to get his hands on a piece of bread due to pity from the baker because the reaping was coming up, Katniss states, “It’s real bakery bread, not the flat, dense loaves we make from our grain rations” (Hunger 7). She inhales the scent of the bread and eats the bread in complete awe. Surprisingly, in her district, bakery bread is not something that is common. Another example is when Rue is eating a piece of a roasted bird that Katniss had shot for them in the arena. She exclaims, “I’ve never had a whole leg to myself before” (Hunger 202). Although no food is provided during the games, Rue is eating better than when she is at home, as planned by the government as part of their strategies of control. Another instance in which the government uses food as a strategy of control toward the tributes is when Katniss and Peeta get onboard the Tribute train and see more food than they have ever seen in their lives. Katniss points out, “Throughout the meal, Effie Trinket keeps reminding us to save space because there’s more to come. But I’m stuffing myself because I’ve never had food like this, so good and so much, and probably the best thing I can do between now and the Games is put on a few pounds” (Hunger 44). Katniss specifically points out that she needs to “put on a few pounds” which suggests that she is underweight currently due to the lack of food and other resources at home. However, Effie’s first thought, as a wealthy Capitol citizen and as Katniss and Peeta’s escort, is to “save space” for more food, which shows that she sees food as an experience, rather than as a life necessity. This shows the comfort and reliability she feels in her food supply thanks to being a

citizen of the Capitol. Nonetheless, Katniss and Peeta are overeating because their malnourished bodies are begging for it and unlike Effie, they do not usually have opportunities like this one. Effie inadvertently brings attention to the starving tributes when she explains that she is amazed that Katniss and Peeta eat with manners on the Tribute train because “The pair last year ate everything with their hands like a couple of savages” (Hunger 44). By referring to these prior tributes as “a couple of savages” Collins emphasizes the level of starvation and deprivation of the tributes for they were probably acting out of character; they surely would not have eaten like “savages” if they had been back at home. Unable to understand the class struggle and the hunger among the Districts, Effie judges these poor children for eating without manners. It can be inferred that Effie is judgmental due to her ignorance and lack of freedom in the Capitol. She is “caged” and kept from the truth around her; she fails to see anything besides what the government shows her. Effie’s loyalty to the Capitol, as well as all the other citizens’ loyalty, is bought. In general, the Capitol ensures that the tributes have better resources on the brink of their own deaths than on a regular day of their lives. By having this lavish display of foods, the Capitol is showing them what they are fighting for, a better future, like the future of the Capitol’s citizens. If they put on a good show and survive the games, they themselves could be a part of this fantasy lifestyle. Thus, in this situation, President Snow is doing to the tributes what he does to the Capitol’s citizens- buying their loyalty and ensuring everything goes as planned. Nevertheless, the districts’ deprivation of basic life necessities such as food and medical care are resisted by the citizens’ illegal hunting, black markets, and resourcefulness.

### **Chapter 3: Oppression of the Tributes through Surveillance and Manipulation**

As if forced participation in the Hunger Games, exploitation, and starvation were not enough forms of oppression, tributes are also abused by Gamemakers throughout the games. Gamemakers manipulate and abuse gamers in the arena to obtain the results they want. The fact they are thrown into an arena to fight till death is horrific in itself; however, the abuse in the arena makes it even worse. Mesut Günenç explains, “In the annual Hunger Games, the Capitol uses technological weapons to control each contestant and even to kill them in the arena. The Capitol also provides weapons to each contestant to learn how they use different weapons for the purpose of killing themselves and how they hunt each other in the arena” (1093). In other words, the Capitol uses surveillance and discipline to adjust and manipulate the actions of the tributes. The Gamemakers even manipulate the arena when they want tributes to get closer to each other. Thus, even in the games the Capitol is able to enact fear into the tributes. For instance, in the 74<sup>th</sup> Hunger Games, when they want Katniss to stop hiding in safety and to get closer to danger and the other tributes, they set a fire in her direction. She points out, “Swirls of smoke catch the sunbeams. My visibility is poor. I can see maybe fifteen yards in any direction” (Hunger 177). The Gamemakers not only use the fire to lead Katniss towards the other tributes, but also to weaken her. Although the Capitol claims that the Hunger Games is a fight till death between the tributes, it really is not, since the Gamemakers are involved in the fight too. This puts the power of the tributes’ lives into the hands of the Capitol, yet again. Therefore, even inside the Hunger Games, the tributes do not have their own autonomy. The narrator explains that the Capitol does this to ensure that the game does not get boring and to ensure that the right tribute wins. Nonetheless, the Victors seem to have some hope as they find ways to go against the Gamemakers during the 74<sup>th</sup> Hunger Games, such as when Katniss breaks the rules during

training ranking. When Katniss sees that the Gamemakers are too busy chatting and eating, not taking her seriously, she realizes there is no force field protecting the Gamemakers from the tributes and decides to shoot at them, perfectly aiming and hitting an apple on their table. This scene is important as Collins shows the reader that Katniss is not afraid to be confrontational with the Gamemakers. This part also sticks out to me because although Katniss holds so much hatred for these government officials, she does not choose to kill any of them, but rather to intimidate them. Although the government wants to see killers in their games, these are merely children with morals. Katniss does not even think of harming someone who is plotting her own demise in the arena. The Hunger Games is supposed to show the districts that the Capitol is in charge and that the tributes' lives are simply expendable. However, by helping each other, Katniss and some of the tributes remind everyone that they are real people with real lives, which is a form of resistance against the Capitol.

Furthermore, in *Catching Fire*, the abuse from the Gamemakers intensifies as the government realizes that they need to control the Victors who are now in the Quarter Quell 75<sup>th</sup> Hunger Games. The Quarter Quell is a special edition of the Hunger Games done every 25 years to celebrate the Capitol's victory during the first rebellion. Basically, the Quarter Quell is another chance for the Capitol to come up with new rules and to display their abuse of power. In "Consumed: Food in the Hunger Games" by Lori Parks and Jennifer Yamashiro, they point out that, "The Hunger Games act as a public venue of torture that annually exacts the supreme power Snow has over his subjects" (141). Here, Parks and Yamashiro emphasize the fact that the games revolve around "torture" which is a key component in this dictatorial country dominated by oppression. Furthermore, the use of the word "subjects" to refer to the people of Panem, further shows the role of the citizens in relation to the Capitol. As "subjects," the people of the districts

are meant to serve and obey President Snow. The torture is worse during this Quarter Quell as these Victors are considered “royalty” to the districts. Due to their victory in a previous game, they have become a form of hope and resistance within the districts, thus the Capitol wants to end their lives to avoid any uprising. The Gamemakers plan to remove these tributes from the picture in several ways; some of their methods include sentimental hallucinations, poisonous fog, and the extreme spinning of the cornucopia. The hallucinations occur when the Capitol seeks more entertainment; to torment the tributes, they release a jabberjay into the arena, which is a bird that mimics sounds that the tributes have heard before. For example, Katniss and Finnick hear the voices of their loved ones in the arena and worry because they believe their loved ones are being tormented to produce these hallucinations. These Victors are aware that the Capitol will do anything possible to get rid of them, including harming their families. During one of the hallucinations, Katniss thinks “*It wasn’t real, I tell myself. The same way the mutation wolves last year weren’t really the dead tributes. It’s just a sadistic trick of the Gamemakers*” (Catching 341). The words “It’s just a sadistic trick” do not just confirm that the government takes pleasure on the suffering of the gamers, but it also shows that there is no doubt on behalf of the Victors whether the government would be behind something as cruel as this. Furthermore, the Gamemakers also use poison fog to abuse the Victors and achieve their own goals. When Katniss sees the fog in the arena she thinks, “Something’s wrong with this fog. The progression of the front line is too uniform to be natural. And if it’s not natural...” (Catching 297). This is Katniss’s realization that the fog is not natural but artificially made by the Gamemakers, yet another means of control on their behalf. It was “too uniform” because it was created specifically to target them and to stop the allying between the Victors. It is because of this fog that Mags, the female Victor from District 4, dies as she deliberately walks into the fog while trying to ensure

the safety of her allies. Mags's sacrifice shows resistance against the Capitol's control because she does not only save her rivals in the game, but she also grants herself a merciful death, without bloodshed, something against the rules of the games since she is taking control of her own life. By helping each other, the Victors are showing humanity to one another regardless of the Capitol's menacing ways, hence, propelling the beginning of the Capitol's downfall.

Furthermore, when the Gamemakers realize that Katniss and her allies have noticed that the cornucopia is like a clock that hints at hourly occurrences, the Gamemakers are immediately fearful that she and her allies could easily win by using the cornucopia, their own technology, against them. This would lead to the districts questioning the government's control over the arena. The cornucopia is a giant horn with supplies needed to survive in the arena; it is used to attract and encourage the tributes to fight. This is the Capitol's way to ensure the division among the tributes from the very beginning of the games. Katniss points out, "Suddenly the ground jerks beneath my feet and I'm flung on my side in the sand. The circle of land that holds the Cornucopia starts spinning fast, really fast, and I can see the jungle going by in a blur" (Catching 333). The mention of the words "jerks," "flung" and "blur" emphasize just how fast and dangerously the cornucopia was moving. The Gamemakers put the Victors in their place by reinforcing their claim to the cornucopia and using it to disorient some of them while eliminating others. Overall, Collins portrays a government that is deceiving and irreverent, a government that proclaims Victors, but ultimately takes their freedom away in the snap of a finger. As part of the government's plan of oppression, they provide temporary hope, only to strip it away when they deem it necessary.

Nonetheless, the 75<sup>th</sup> Hunger Games Victors find ways to go against the Gamemakers, thus depicting possibilities and limits of resistance. In *Catching Fire*, Collins has Katniss and

Peeta rebel during the ranking out of anger over the way in which the Victors are treated. As a form of resistance, Katniss decides to show the Gamemakers her knot-tying skills by presenting a target dummy with Seneca Crane's name, the previous Head Gamemaker who had been recently killed by President Snow for allowing her and Peeta to win the games together. This is a powerful and controversial move on Katniss's behalf, as it is her way of showing that she is aware that President Snow has killed Seneca, thus revealing to the Capitol's citizens that no one is safe, not even the Head Gamemaker. She is also showing President Snow that she is not submissive to his control. Furthermore, Peeta also goes against the Gamemakers, by painting a photo of Rue after Katniss buries her. To defend these actions, Katniss thinks to herself, "I'd love to do just that and more. To break through the smug veneer of those who use their brains to find amusing ways to kill us. To make them realize that while we're vulnerable to the Capitol's cruelties, they are as well" (Catching 236). Here, Katniss brings attention to the pretentiousness of these Gamemakers who appear "smug" as if they were not sentencing 24 people to their possible deaths and as if they did not know that they could be next. Furthermore, another form of resistance during the games is when one of the tributes, Johanna, shouts, "'The whole country adores Katniss's little sister. If they really killed her like this, they'd probably have an uprising on their hands,' says Johanna flatly. 'Don't want that, do they?' She throws back her head and shouts, 'Whole country in rebellion? Wouldn't want anything like that!'" (Catching 346). This is impactful and probably the most powerful statement of resistance throughout the trilogy, as Johanna blatantly discusses the cruelties of the Capitol and openly suggests the idea of a rebellion knowing that she is being broadcasted in all the districts and in the Capitol. Interestingly, Collins chooses to have Johanna, instead of Katniss, do this. She portrays Johanna as a force to be reckoned with and a heroine. Of course, it is explained that Johanna does not fear



the Capitol because she has no one she loves left, so the government cannot torture her by threatening anyone she loves. Both Katniss and Johanna seek justice, but Katniss is held back by fear that the government might hurt her family. Thus, Johanna is the ideal embodiment of resistance for she is openly attacking the Capitol and urging the districts to partake in the revolution. Lastly, one of the greatest moments of resistance in the trilogy takes place during the 75<sup>th</sup> Hunger Games when the rebels break out from the arena. Haymitch, District 12's Victor and mentor, teams up with the new Head Gamemaker, Plutarch Heavensbee, to break into the arena and rescue the Victors. Katniss, unknowingly, aids the plan by shooting her arrow into a forcefield, an electric invisible barrier that prevents tributes from escaping the arena. This causes a huge explosion that allows the rebel aircraft to enter the arena to rescue some of the Victors. Katniss learns, "There was a plan to break us out of the arena from the moment the Quell was announced. The Victors from Districts 3, 4, 6, 7, 8 and 11 had varying degrees of knowledge about it" (Catching 385). The fact that nearly all the districts were working together to keep Katniss and Peeta alive, thus keeping the rebellion alive, shows a new level of resistance. This rescue shows the power of hope and the importance of unity with respect to igniting change in the face of social injustice. The districts' solidarity makes it possible for them to gain strength and courage to fight back and ensure Katniss's and some of the other Victors' safety. As the "Mockingjay," Katniss has become their symbol of hope, and they need her to be part of the revolution.

## **Chapter 4: Oppression of the Districts' Citizens through Intimidation, Brutality, and Murder**

Another form of oppression in the trilogy is the use of Peacekeepers, agents of oppression who maintain order by assaulting the citizens within the districts. In the beginning of the trilogy, the Peacekeepers in District 12 are not corrupt. In fact, they often speak to the people in the districts and are friendly. However, once a spark of rebellion is perceived within the districts, these kind Peacekeepers are replaced by cruel abusive ones. President Snow uses these corrupt Peacekeepers to enforce oppression within the districts when he feels his power is being threatened. When the new Peacekeepers come in, Collins explains through Katniss's perspective, "Everything about this man, his commanding voice, his odd accent, warns of an unknown and dangerous threat. Where has he come from? District 11? 3? From the Capitol itself?" (Catching 107). She labels this man a "threat" which informs the reader he most likely will bring nothing but trouble because despite the name "Peacekeeper," he has been sent to wreak chaos rather than bring peace. Nonetheless, to the Capitol, this title "Peacekeeper" further backs up their ideology that violent control brings peace. Katniss describes seeing Gale at the whipping post "Gale's wrists are bound to a wooden post. The wild turkey he shot earlier hangs above him, the nail driven through its neck. His jacket's been cast aside on the ground, his shirt torn away" (Catching 104). Collins paints a picture of the situation here by pointing out, "the wild turkey he shot earlier hangs above him" which reminds the reader that Gale had broken the rules of the government by hunting, thus leading to this lashing. Although this lashing is severe and terrifying, Katniss shows courage and brotherhood when she intervenes to save Gale from the Peacekeeper. By doing so, she is showing her opposition to oppression, and thus ultimately to the Capitol. Once she jumps in and is not recognized by the Peacekeeper, Haymitch and Peeta jump

in to assist her. She has encouraged others to do the same. Immediately the Peacekeeper recognizes the Victors, and they create a spectacle of resistance. Prior to this point in the trilogy, there had not been a spectacle of resistance this grand in any of the districts as no one had the power, nor the tenacity, to do so. However, Katniss, Haymitch, and Peeta, having been previous Victors, feel they can go against the Peacekeeper's expectations as they have endured and survived the Hunger Games. They have the strength and the confidence to defend themselves, regardless of the consequences. Collins's narrator thinks to herself, "Maybe we're it. The only three people in the district who could make a stand like this. Although it's sure to be temporary. There will be repercussions. But at the moment, all I care about is keeping Gale alive" (*Catching* 108). All three of them know that there will be consequences to their actions; yet they choose to challenge President Snow's orders to save Gale. When Katniss, Haymitch, and Peeta stand in solidarity, they are not only sending a message to President Snow; they are also letting everyone know that their entrapment is over. Nonetheless, by having Katniss point out the power that just the three of them have, Collins brings attention to the strength in coming together in the face of oppression.

Additionally, these Peacekeepers do not just physically harm the districts' citizens, they also murder people who get in their way. The narrator points out in *Catching Fire*, that when she and Peeta are going district to district after their victory in the 74<sup>th</sup> Hunger Games, they show great remorse, even honoring Thresh and Rue, the dead tributes from District 11. This alone infuriates the Capitol as President Snow has threatened Katniss to stay in line after the whole act with the poisonous berries during the 74<sup>th</sup> Games. Thus, when Katniss and Peeta receive positive feedback from the people of District 11, the Peacekeepers make sure they punish these supporters. During the honoring of Thresh and Rue, a man begins to whistle the same way that

Rue did with Katniss during the Games. This gesture becomes another spectacle of resistance inspiring every other person in the crowd to raise their three middle fingers to their lips and then into the sky, which is a tradition in District 12. By doing this gesture, the people of District 11 are showing appreciation and support to Katniss for being kind to Rue. This kindness and solidarity are not appreciated by the Capitol, as suddenly Collins describes that Katniss and Peeta see, “A pair of Peacekeepers dragging the old man who whistled to the top of the steps. Forcing him to his knees before the crowd. And putting a bullet through his head” (Catching 62). This quote further shows President Snow’s tactics to rule and control by fear. This murder is only the beginning of this mistreatment as when the victory tour comes to its end, Katniss mentions seeing, “Several of the soldiers have automatic weapons held lengthwise as they push us back toward the door” (Catching 63). The mention of “soldiers” and “automatic weapons” makes the districts sound as though a war is going on. It is interesting to me that the narrator does not say “Peacekeepers” here but rather “soldiers” as it shows the reader what she really thinks of these individuals and her environment. Ironically, Peacekeepers maintain “peace” in the districts by killing and inflicting fear on the townspeople. In my opinion, by doing this, Collins stresses the severity of the situation since soldiers are meant to protect the government against invasion, the invasion being Katniss’s supporters who are willing to resist regardless of the consequences. Collins is suggesting that the war has already begun.

## Chapter 5: Oppression of the “Rebels” through Limitations, Threats, and Mutilation

Another form of oppression shown in the trilogy is that of those who commit “crimes” that are considered rebellious by the government. The Hunger Games were quite literally created to punish rebels for going against the Capitol; thus, the government does not take rebellion of any sort lightly. The people of the districts are expected to follow their government and never vocalize their own apprehension about anything. Van Dyke discusses the government’s expectations in her article, “Discipline and the Docile Body: Regulating Hungers in the Capitol,” by stating that “In District 12, for instance, social norms include keeping one’s head down and avoiding attention, as well as keeping any dissatisfaction with the government quiet and avoiding large social gatherings. This indicates, among other things, a repressive system of government likely to crack down on anyone who draws attention or resists openly” (5-6). This quote specifies the extreme limits placed on the people within the districts. Not only are they expected to be quiet, but they also are required to avoid “large social gatherings,” which shows the complete distrust that President Snow has of his citizens. This is his way of ensuring that there is no spread of defiant language against the Capitol, thus preventing any possible riots from the districts. In fact, Katniss mentions, “When I was younger, I scared my mother to death, the things I would blurt out about District 13, about the people who rule our country, Panem, from the far-off city called the Capitol. Eventually I understood this would only lead us to more trouble” (Hunger 6). The words “scared” and “trouble” emphasize that rebelling comes with severe consequences. This is the first time District 13 is mentioned in the trilogy. Later the narrator mentions that this district had vanished due to a rebellion. By pointing out the fear that Katniss’s mother has with Katniss’s outspokenness, Collins is justifying the districts’ compliance and obedience. This fear is justified throughout the trilogy, as when anyone partakes in any sort of act of rebellion, they

are immediately punished. As mentioned earlier, when Katniss threatens to eat the poisonous berries with Peeta, President Snow immediately visits her to remind her that he is in control. He worries that the districts may be inspired by Katniss' spectacular act of resistance and commit acts of resistance, such as hers. As President Snow does not receive a straightforward answer from Katniss, he goes on to threaten her, "Speak, Miss Everdeen. Him I can easily kill off if we don't come to a happy resolution. You aren't doing him a favor by disappearing into the woods with him each Sunday" (Catching 24). Here, President Snow is threatening Katniss by reminding her that he holds the power over life and death. It is important to note that President Snow has known of her illegal hunting with Gale and yet chooses not to mention it until this specific moment. In Andrea Nikoloso's essay "The Dystopian Elements in Suzanne Collins's *The Hunger Games*," she proposes that the "Capitol collects pieces of information wherever they can and then decides when and how to use them against their citizens" (17). Nikoloso makes a great point of emphasizing the possibility that the Capitol is aware of their citizen's unlawful actions and purposely does not confront them until they can use it to their advantage. This is exactly what President Snow does with Katniss when he chooses not to have Katniss and Gale punished but waits until he can use it to manipulate them. He specifically keeps a close eye on Katniss, the Mockingjay, because she is dangerous to his dictatorship.

Additionally, the government is known for doing many other unspeakable things to those who go against them. For instance, we are shown how the government reacts to its "traitors" when we find out about an occurrence that Katniss has while out hunting in the woods with Gale. She mentions seeing a girl and a boy running away from something with great horror when a hovercraft appeared and took the girl and killed the boy. This girl is then taken by the Capitol and turned into an Avox. When Katniss sees this girl while in the Capitol before the 74<sup>th</sup> games,

she is convinced that she is the same girl she once saw in the woods that day. Haymitch Abernathy, the District 12 mentor, reminds Katniss that that girl is, “Someone who committed a crime. They cut her tongue so she can’t speak. She’s probably a traitor of some sort. Not likely you’d know her” (Hunger 77). By primarily emphasizing that she “committed a crime,” Haymitch almost justifies the consequences that she had to endure. At this point in the trilogy, Haymitch has accepted the inhumane mistreatment of rebels from the Capitol. This shows the power of the Capitol in ensuring that all citizens recognize their law as final. Even Haymitch, a previous Victor who does not support the Capitol, has lost hope and consequently given up his own opinion and begun going along with the Capitol. Additionally, Haymitch informs Katniss of the severity in which an Avox is punished, through the mutilation of their tongue. This shows that the Capitol quite literally silences their traitors by ensuring that they cannot speak. Threats are sometimes not efficient enough for the Capitol, which leads to them inflicting fear through physical bodily torture, as well. Furthermore, Haymitch states that it is “not likely you’d know her” which implies that traitors are out of reach, unknown to regular citizens. This phrase makes it seem as though rebels are in their own world, barely a part of regular society. This suggests to me that once someone in the districts is a traitor, they are shunned. This girl is not the only Avox that Katniss encounters while in the Capitol. Additionally, in the 75<sup>th</sup> Hunger Games, Katniss sees Darius, a past Peacekeeper of District 12, who has now been turned into an Avox due to a disagreement he had with the new, cruel Peacekeepers sent from the Capitol. Before heading into the games, Darius is assigned to be Katniss’s personal Avox, aiding and assisting her with anything. This is purposeful as President Snow has Darius assigned to Katniss to make her feel guilty, as it is due to him standing up against Gale being lashed that he has been punished in this way. This shows that President Snow continues to seek Katniss’s suffering to remind her that she

is not as strong as she thinks and that he holds all the power. He is also attempting to convince her that it is entirely her fault that Darius ended up as an Avox, thus deluding her into thinking that all resistance ends with loss. This is a psychological oppressive tactic that President Snow enjoys using. He wants Katniss to understand that if Darius could become an Avox, so can any of her family members or friends, as repercussion for her behavior. Katniss thinks to herself, “I know any move I make toward Darius, any act of recognition, would only result in punishment for him. So we just stare into each other’s eyes” (Catching 218). The fact that Katniss must hide her “recognition” of Darius to ensure that he does not receive worse repercussions reinforces the feelings of entrapment that Katniss and the districts’ citizens feel. Since Avoxes are forcibly stripped of their right to free speech, they do not only suffer physically, but psychologically too. They are completely stripped of hope through their mutilation and abuse, thus silencing them and keeping them away from rebellion. Although Katniss and Darius simply “stare into each other’s eyes,” with no words stated, it is as though the two share a conversation. One simple stare between Katniss and Darius reveals her guilt and his pain, as well as the cruel repercussions of being considered a rebel in Panem.



## **Chapter 6: Oppression of the Victors of the Hunger Games through Torture, Sexual Abuse, and Surveillance**

Even though the Victors of the Hunger Games are promised safety and comfort after the games, it is clear through their treatment afterwards that they are being deceived. As Katniss mentions, she has had many worries for her future, such as raising a child in the districts, but her fears never included going back into the games. She thinks to herself, “Victors are out of the reaping for life. That’s the deal if you win. Until now” (Catching 175). The usage of the word “deal” suggests that there is a social contract or an agreement between the Capitol and the districts. Furthermore, the usage of the word “win” suggests that even Katniss herself has accepted the Capitol’s viewpoint that this bloodshed in the arena is merely a winnable game. This shows the grasp that the Capitol has on not only the wealthy Capitol’s individuals, but also on those of the districts. However, this belief that one can “win” the games is refuted in Francis Lawrence’s film adaptation of *Catching Fire*, in which Haymitch states, “Nobody ever wins the games. Period. There are survivors but there’s no winners.” Here, Haymitch states the reality that although Victors are alive, they will never be free, which is something that the Capitol does not reveal to the districts. To exert their power against these “survivors” of the games, the Capitol uses force and violence against them. For instance, after the 75<sup>th</sup> games, the Capitol is furious over the rebellion enacted by the Victors to escape, so they seek to punish them. The Capitol takes the Victors who are not able to escape with the rebels into custody and physically abuses them to manipulate them. For instance, President Snow has Peeta abused both physically and psychologically, to use him as a weapon against Katniss, the Mockingjay of the rebellion. They dissect Peeta’s mind and manipulate his finest memories with Katniss, showing that even the citizens’ internal thoughts can be literally controlled and altered by the government. This

reinforces just how oppressive the government of Panem is, having no limits when it comes to control. When seeing Peeta being broadcasted, Katniss thinks, “The healthy, clear-eyed boy I saw a few days ago has lost at least fifteen pounds and developed a nervous tremor in his hands. They’ve still got him groomed, but underneath the paint that cannot cover the bags under his eyes, and the fine clothes that cannot conceal the pain he feels when he moves, is a person badly damaged” (Mockingjay 112). Clearly, President Snow is not just brainwashing Peeta; he is also mistreating him. The mention of the loss of “fifteen pounds,” and “bags under his eyes” makes it evident that Peeta has been starved and abused. He even has a “nervous tremor” which is an involuntary condition thus confirming torture and distress. Additionally, by using Peeta as his own personal weapon to deceive the citizens of Panem, President Snow is letting rebels know that regardless of what they think they can accomplish, Peeta, and everyone he represents, are just pawns in his game. When the rebels free Peeta from the Capitol’s torture, they find that without his memories of Katniss and what she stands for, Peeta has lost hope in the rebellion and any resistance at all. Nonetheless, as mentioned in Katie Stockdale’s, *Hope Under Oppression*, “Oppression threatens hope, but it does not necessarily succeed in damaging or destroying it. It is a remarkable fact that certain people are capable of sustaining hope despite the conditions in which they find themselves, and some members of oppressed groups are capable of sustaining hope even when their hopes are not likely to be realized” (27). Stockdale explains that although oppression can cause hopelessness, it does not always succeed, as we can see in Peeta’s case. With the help of Katniss and a few others who never lose hope for him, Peeta is able to resist his mind’s tricks and work towards becoming the person that he used to be. Therefore, Collins shows that despite immense trauma, hope is always reachable.

As if intimidating the Victors through brainwashing and torture were not enough, President Snow also uses sexual abuse as a form of oppression on some of them. For instance, during a nationwide broadcast, Finnick tells all Panem about his oppressive experiences with the Capitol, “President Snow used to... sell me... my body, that is. I wasn’t the only one. If a Victor is considered desirable, the president gives them as a reward or allows people to buy them for an exorbitant amount of money. If you refuse, he kills someone you love. So you do it” (Mockingjay 170). The words “sell me” show that Finnick was viewed merely as a sexual slave. This shows how President Snow deprives the citizens of Panem from basic human rights such as bodily integrity. Finnick goes on to say that he is not the only one who was viewed this way, and that other Victors also had their bodies sold. Therefore, this form of oppression is common among the Victors. This is a grand moment of resistance as Finnick does not allow the Capitol to dictate his actions even though the Capitol has kidnapped the person most important to him. Nonetheless, Finnick is consumed with hope in the rebellion and chooses instead to publicly broadcast his abusive experiences in the Capitol. Not even President Snow’s threats and physical abuse destroy the hope of the Victors.

Another form of oppression against the Victors is coercion through constant surveillance. President Snow coerces the Victors into acting the way he wants by violating their privacy when they return to the districts. Once back in their districts, it is as though they are still a part of the games, as they are still being watched and controlled by the government. The Capitol makes sure that the Victors understand that they are only living because they have allowed them to live. In “Consumed: Food in The Hunger Games,” by Lori Parks and Jennifer Yamashiro, they argue that “Power is about relationships and how they impact each other. It is not simply physical, it can also involve mental and emotional persuasion that might restrict or alter a person’s will”

(141). I think that Parks and Yamashiro make a great point emphasizing that power can involve both “mental and emotional persuasion” because that is exactly how President Snow controls the Victors of the Hunger Games. To make sure that uprisings do not occur, President Snow monitors Katniss and ensures that she lives her life the way that he wishes. In fact, Haymitch reminds Katniss, “You and Peeta, you’ll be mentors now, every year from here on out. And every year they’ll revisit the romance and broadcast the details of your private life, and you’ll never, ever be able to do anything but live happily ever after with that boy” (Catching 44). Haymitch emphasizes that “every year they’ll revisit the romance” which shows that the Capitol will keep an eye on her indefinitely. She will be forced to live a “happily ever after life” with Peeta and nothing else. As Katniss and Peeta are now Capitol entertainment, they are going to be spectacles for the rest of their lives. Consequently, Katniss tells herself, “He means there’s only one future, if I want to keep those I love alive and stay alive myself. I’ll have to marry Peeta” (Catching 44). She realizes that her only solution is to marry Peeta and convince President Snow that she is innocent and in love. Thus, President Snow even controls the citizens’ right to consensual marriage. With years of experience, it is obvious that Haymitch knows much about the Capitol’s tactics of oppression. Collins makes this evident when Katniss and Peeta watch the video footage from the 50<sup>th</sup> Hunger Games in which Haymitch was a tribute and see that he himself created a rebellious scene in his arena by cleverly using the Capitol’s technology against them. Katniss concludes that, “They never planned on anyone using it as a weapon. It made them look stupid that he figured it out. I bet they had a good time trying to spin that one. Bet that’s why I don’t remember seeing it on television. It’s almost as bad as us and the berries!” (Catching 202). The fact that Katniss mentions that she does not remember seeing Haymitch’s act of resistance on television” tells me that the Capitol attempts to rid of all traces of it, in order to

ensure that their power and control is not threatened publicly. Katniss explains that Haymitch had used the Capitol's forcefield as "a weapon" thus finding a way to use the Capitol's technology to attack other tributes, which is not allowed in the games. This is an intense moment of rebellion, as Katniss even compares it to being "almost as bad" as her play with the berries. Therefore, it can be inferred that Haymitch obeys the Capitol because he has also been physically and psychologically tortured. In fact, Haymitch is always intoxicated and has never mentioned his family; perhaps the dictatorial government has killed them. Thus, when he meets Katniss and Peeta, he puts in zero effort to teach them how to survive in the games. However, when he realizes they show promise, he asks, "Well, what's this? Did I actually get a pair of fighters this year?" (Hunger 57). His curiosity peaks as he sees potential in the two of them and he specifically questions whether they are "fighters" as being able to fight is essential for surviving the games. Katniss and Peeta provide Haymitch with the motivation to remain sober from alcohol and actually try his best to ensure their survival. This shows the power of hope that Katniss and Peeta provide from the beginning of the trilogy. Another Victor who is tortured by President Snow, but remains hopeful is Johanna. She is not only kidnapped and electrocuted after the 75<sup>th</sup> Hunger Games, but she has also lost all her family members. She explains, "They can't hurt me. I'm not like the rest of you. There's no one left I love" (Catching 347), implying that President Snow has already had her family killed. If this is the reason her family is dead, this shows Johanna's strength and lack of conformity. Even without her family, she holds out hope for a better future, one without a corrupt government. Johanna is an interesting character because even without any family alive, she is portrayed as one of those certain people, as described by Stockdale, who never lose hope. Nonetheless, her hope for revenge gives her the motivation she needs to fight and not give up. Therefore, President Snow's psychological torture is not as

effective as he believes it is, as the Victors are fueled with rage and resist even when their loved ones are at risk.

## Chapter 7: The Power of Hope in Resistance During Revolution

As mentioned previously, Collins reveals the power of hope and unity through the multiple layers of resistance depicted in the Hunger Games trilogy, starting with Katniss who quickly becomes the main symbol of hope for the revolution. She inspires the districts from the moment she takes her sister's place in the Hunger Games and then buries Rue showing her courage and compassion for others. Through her brave acts of resistance, she ignites the districts' revolution which begins right after the 75<sup>th</sup> Hunger Games when all the rebels unite in District 13 to overthrow the Capitol. Katniss thinks to herself, "What they want is for me to truly take on the role they designed for me. The symbol of the revolution. The Mockingjay. It isn't enough, what I've done in the past, defying the Capitol in the Games, providing a rallying point. I must now become the actual leader, the face, the voice, the embodiment of the revolution" (Mockingjay 10). Her usage of the word "role" to describe her new position within the rebellion shows that these expectations have become more of a required and intentional duty to her. Additionally, she mentions that her previous moments of resistance, although motivational, are not enough for the revolution to succeed. She is aware that she will need to truly embody a rebel who is unafraid of doing anything it takes to defeat the Capitol, even if that means putting her family at risk. As Katniss travels through District 8, her presence inspires everyone as the districts were not made aware that she had been rescued during the 75<sup>th</sup> Hunger Games. As anticipated, the Capitol does not let this victory proceed without attempting to ruin it. This motivational moment is met with an attack from the Capitol as an attempt to get the districts to blame and dislike Katniss. The best way to describe the way President Snow perceives hope within the districts, is through a quote stated by him in the Francis Lawrence's film adaptation of the *The Hunger Games*. He states, "Hope. It is the only thing stronger than fear. A little hope is effective. A lot of hope is

dangerous. A spark is fine, as long as it's contained." Both the novel President Snow and the film's adaptation of President Snow, understand that district hope can be both motivational and problematic for the government. For that reason, he likes to provide the right amount of hope, just enough to keep people under control. After the attack on District 8, Katniss broadcasts to all Panem, "President Snow says he's sending us a message? Well, I have one for him. You can torture us and bomb us and burn our districts to the ground, but do you see that? Fire is catching! And if we burn, you burn with us!" (*Mockingjay* 106). President Snow's attack against District 8 backfires because instead of dissuading the rebels, they are fueled with anger and become even more hopeful than ever before. The words "fire is catching" emphasize the grand success of the rebellion so far, thus informing the Capitol that they are failing. Additionally, the usage of the phrase "if we burn, you burn with us" is a direct threat from the rebels to the Capitol. When the citizens of Panem see this on television, they are immediately inspired by Katniss's ability to bravely confront the government. She proves time and time again that she is not only protective and compassionate, but she is also strong and violent when she needs to be. Unlike before, now the rebels are the ones threatening their government, thus depicting their newfound power.

Katniss's days of allowing the Capitol to control her are no longer. At another point during the revolution, Katniss broadcasts herself singing an ancient lore rebel song that her father taught her before he passed, called "The Hanging Tree." The first verse of this song is, "Are you, are you/ Coming to the tree/ Where they strung up a man, they say who murdered three. Strange things did happen here" (*Mockingjay* 123). The "tree" that Katniss is referring to is the spot where the Capitol had rebels hung in the center of the district for everyone to see. This specific rebel song is written from the perspective of a man who murders three people, is hung by the Capitol, and then proceeds to beg his lover to meet him at the tree to die by his side. This song shows the



oppressive tactics and cruelty of the Capitol; thus, it is labeled a rebel song and banned in Panem. Through her singing, Katniss expresses her message about the revolution to the districts; she communicates her commitment to the cause. When she sings this song, it motivates the districts to continue resisting against the Capitol and fighting for their freedom. The rebels unite in District 13, reaching an entirely new level of collective resistance regardless of the repercussions.

Although District 13 provides all the districts with hope for a greater future, it also possesses a corrupt leader and corrupt laws like those of the Capitol. As it turns out, the Capitol had a deal with District 13, in which they would pretend to be dead and thus be allowed to live, in exchange for ending the violence and limiting casualties on both sides. It can be assumed that the Capitol only agreed to this because they believed that without resources from the Capitol, District 13 would eventually die off on their own. Because of their triumph, District 13 becomes a symbol of hope to all the districts as they are the only district that has been able to escape the Capitol's grasp successfully and flourish without them. This results in the rebels' blind obedience of President Coin, their own elected President. As Christina Van Dyke writes in her article, "Discipline and the Docile Body: Regulating Hungers in the Capitol," "District 13's rigid control of the citizens' personal and political lives keeps it running in the face of almost insurmountable odds...but it also has indelible effects on the population, perhaps the most noticeable of which is the stoic compliance of the people with a system that allows essentially no room for individual expression" (13). Van Dyke emphasizes the fact that District 13 survives solely because of the political control and structure, as they enforce the "rigid control of the citizens," which includes strict daily schedules, limited resources, as well as severe punishment for crimes. Additionally, "individual expression" is not allowed as all citizens are forced to

uphold the same beliefs of President Coin. President Coin is just as oppressive as President Snow; thus, one cruel dictator has been replaced by another. For instance, when Katniss's sister is killed during a raid, she is quick to blame President Snow, only to find out later that the raid was President Coin's plan. The narrator assumes that President Coin must have wanted to rid of her sister to ensure her feelings of hopelessness, thus never getting in her way. Here, President Coin is using the exact same oppressive tactic that President Snow uses for rebels, as she is willing to dispose of anyone who gets in her way. As Van Dyke goes on to mention, "From the perspective of District 13, Katniss's unforgivable sin is her inability to take orders. In both systems, there is no place for the life that Katniss longs to lead—a life where she can decide for herself what to do and under what conditions" (15). The words "unforgivable sin" shows the severity of disobeying orders within District 13, something which Katniss often does. President Coin fears Katniss because of the influence that she holds over Panem, as the only person with enough respect and trust to one day become a leader herself. President Coin is so much like President Snow that she even wants to have a "symbolic Hunger Games" with the Capitol's children to fully put an end to it all (*Mockingjay* 369). She will do anything it takes to retain her control, even if it means becoming a cruel dictator. While some of the Victors support President Coin's idea for this finale Hunger Games, Katniss does not. She understands that if President Coin is willing to put innocent Capitol children's lives at risk, she can do even worse things; the possibilities are endless. Thus, when Katniss is told that she can eliminate President Snow for his crimes, she takes matters into her own hands and decides to kill President Coin instead. For the first time, Katniss responds physically and violently to oppression by eliminating her threat. President Snow also dies at the end, although his cause of death is not clear. However, thanks to the revolution, Panem no longer has a dictator in charge, thus no more oppression. As Marilyn

Frye proposes in her essay "Oppression," an individual who is oppressed can be compared to a bird confined to a cage unable to escape (12). I view Katniss as a depiction of the entrapped bird that Frye describes as she is quite literally nicknamed after a bird, the Mockingjay. However, unlike a caged bird, Katniss does not take her own capture lightly, and constantly attempts to break-free. Ultimately, Katniss achieves her freedom at the end of the novel, after killing her president. She is told she cannot live in District 13, the rebel district, any longer, and that she must return to her abandoned home, District 12, until further notice. Collins then goes on to describe how years later, Katniss and Peeta have a wonderful future together. They have fallen in love and chosen to have children; their love has not been forced onto them this time, as life is better now. Collins provides a description of their future by giving us a moment in which the two of them are in a meadow with their two happy children, a boy and a girl. The fact that Katniss has decided to have children demonstrates that she lives in a new world; she feels hopeful and free. Katniss explains, "The arenas have been completely destroyed, the memorials built, there are no more Hunger Games. But they teach them at school" (*Mockingjay* 389). The word "destroyed" shows me that Collins' has ended her novel with a world that has truly abolished oppression. Furthermore, she mentions that children learn about the games in school, which shows me that rather than pretending these games never existed, they chose to educate their young minds instead. Katniss' children can live a better life without fear of being reaped for a Hunger Games, ever again.

## Conclusion

Throughout her trilogy of *The Hunger Games*, author Suzanne Collins depicts various forms of oppression and resistance in the fictional nation of Panem. In her first text of the trilogy, *The Hunger Games* (2008), Collins introduces the reader to the Capitol, a government which abuses and takes advantage of their citizens. The citizens all reside in one of the twelve “districts” as Collins refers to them, and each year the Capitol forces two children from each district to partake in the annual Hunger Games, as a reminder of the Capitol’s control and power. The main protagonists, Katniss Everdeen and Peeta Mellark create some uprising over their acts of resistance as tributes in the arena, thus proliferating hope throughout the districts. This victory convinces the other districts that they should have more hope as moments like these are possible. In *Catching Fire* (2009), the reaping rules for the annual Hunger Games is changed and reaped from only previous Victors, to get rid of these providers of hope for the districts. Nonetheless, the Victors are fueled with rage for the Capitol and thus unite to find a way to escape the arena. Thus, Collins shows the importance of unity and hope in resistance. This plan leads to all the districts getting together to rebel against the Capitol. Ultimately, in *Mockingjay* (2010), a true revolution begins in order to overthrow President Snow. This ends with a better future for all of Panem, thus showing the power of resistance in defeating oppression. Although Collins would agree with Katie Stockdale that “Oppression can thus be understood as a threat to hope,” (27) her characters overcome that threat and once they acquire hope, they do not stop thinking about a better future. Therefore, it is clear that oppression and hope directly coexist with one another as hope is essential to resist and overcome oppression.

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